

It's May 19, 1919.

Your entire country is under attack from every direction.

And none of the higher command seems to care.

You are a simple soldier watching your homeland crumble.

So you take matters into your own hands.

You travel across the country, gathering people who are willing to stand with you,
to push back, and to reclaim your nation.

Four years pass.

The war is won.

Turkey is free.

But your work is not finished.

Even though the Ottoman Empire has fallen,
its shadow still hangs over the nation's future.

You begin transforming the state from its foundations.

You abolish the Sultanate and build the Republic.

You create the Parliament and the Presidency.

You secularize the nation and separate religion and state.

You replace the old alphabet with a modern one,
you raise literacy, you modernize culture, and you change identity forever.

And on November 10, 1938, you leave the country with the legacy of Mustafa Kemal
Atatürk.

But the story does not end here.

This was a mistake.

As time passed, the leaders that came after Atatürk got worse.

They abandoned his ideals and allowed personal power and political interests to take precedence over the nation.

And this is where my monument begins.

Enter “Hayal Kırıklığı”, translated “Disappointment.”

It is a 3.8-meter figure of a kneeling Atatürk, cast in galvanized steel.

One hand supporting himself, the other using his fedora to cover his face.

Not in shame, but in sorrow.

The work symbolizes a founder who cannot bear to see what became of his dream.

It represents the emotional weight that leaders carried after him—
and the burden we now inherit.

I chose galvanized steel because it is durable, industrial, and unbreakable.

Its surface is textured and raw, reflecting struggle and age.

Over time, the metal will weather and darken naturally,
just like the history it refers to.

The monument is located at the busiest public space in Kadıköy,
directly in front of the ferry terminal where thousands pass every day.

It transforms a simple transit space into a space of confrontation and memory.
Kadıköy is a crossroads of ideologies, protests, and expression—
which makes it the perfect stage for this question:

Have we honored the legacy we inherited?
Or have we allowed it to collapse?

This monument is not just celebrating Atatürk.
It celebrates the courage of building a republic from nothing.
And it celebrates the courage to admit that we are failing him.

The viewers are everyday commuters, residents, and citizens of Istanbul.
People from every background and belief are forced to walk past this figure.
The monument is designed to be unavoidable.
It demands reflection and forces a conversation that Turkey continues to avoid.

The plaque reads:

HAYAL KIRIKLIĞI

A tribute to the weight of legacy and the silence of disappointment.
Created anonymously — a sacrifice for safety and expression.
For the citizens of Türkiye.

This sculpture does not fade into the background.
It activates public space.
It invites debate, discomfort, and even disagreement.

It reminds each passerby that the dream of the Republic is not guaranteed.

Because Atatürk's story ended in 1938.

But ours continues today.

And the responsibility now belongs to us.

Thank you.